International Conference on Timbre 2026 - Call for Participation

The 4th edition of the **International Conference on Timbre --** https://timbreconference.org/timbre2026-cfp/ -- will be held in Montréal from J**uly 2 to 4, 2026**, hosted by **University of Montréal** in collaboration with the research partnership **ACTOR** (Analysis, Creation and Teaching of Orchestration), and with the support of Montreal-based music research centres **CIRMMT** (Centre for Interdisciplinary Research in Music Media and Technology) and **RC·MS** (Regroupement inter-universitaire de recherche et création - musiques et sociétés).

Please fill in this form to submit your proposal.
Note that the section allowing you to include an abstract will appear once you have chosen a presentation format.

1. Your **name** : *

Jamie Gabriel

2. Your **affiliation** : *

University of Technology, Sydney

3. Your **email** address : *

jamie@jamiegabriel.org

4. Your **status** : *

- ○ Graduate student
- ○ Professor/researcher
- ◉ Independant researcher or artist

5. Please select all **topics** and **disciplines** which apply to your proposal. NB: You can mention complementary options in the last section of this form. *

- [ ] Orchestration and composition
- [ ] Electroacoustic music and sound art
- [x] Instrumental/vocal performance and improvisation
- [ ] Sound recording
- [ ] Room acoustics
- [ ] Analysis of creative processes
- [ ] Psychoacoustics and auditory perception
- [ ] Neuroscientific approaches

- [ ] Embodiment and crossmodality
- [ ] Gestural control and biomechanical approaches
- [ ] Organology, lutherie and acoustic instrument design
- [x] Human-computer interaction and digital instrument design
- [x] Computational and AI insights and applications
- [ ] Digital signal processing
- [ ] Notation and graphical representations
- [x] Semantics and semiotics
- [ ] Music theory and analysis
- [x] Popular music and jazz studies
- [ ] Sound studies
- [ ] Sound ecology, ecomusicology, zoomusicology
- [ ] Historical perspectives
- [ ] Aesthetic and philosophical perspectives
- [ ] Ethnomusicological, cultural, and sociological perspectives
- [ ] Pedagogical perspectives

6. Please provide a **title** for your proposal : *

From Timbre to Symbol: Semiotic Feedback Loops in Machine-Augmented Improvisation

7. (if applicable) Please indicate the names of your **collaborators** or **research supervisor(s)** and their affiliations.

Mark Evans, University of Technology, Sydney
Sally Jamila, Independent Artist, Aotearoa/New Zealand

8. Please select one **presentation format** : *

- ○ Research presentation
- ● Artistic report
- ○ Panel session or workshop

9. An **artistic report** can include the presentation of up to 10 minutes of musical works or excerpts, either performed live or diffused on the sound system. Authors should indicate in their abstract if they would also like to propose an acoustic or electroacoustic work for inclusion in a concert during the conference, pending selection by the committee and availability of concert

spaces. NB: Authors will be responsible for providing any necessary performers.

Please type or paste here your **abstract** of maximum 4000 characters (500 to 700 words). NB: Do not include the list of references. You will be invited to provide it in the next section. *

Western art music has historically privileged the score as the primary site of musical knowledge. Notation functions as a symbolic system that precedes sound, organising pitch, rhythm, harmony, and form before any performance takes place. Even in jazz and improvised traditions, where the score may be reduced, flexible, or absent altogether, symbolic abstractions such as chord symbols, lead sheets, and formal schemas often continue to underpin planned musical actions. Yet much of what musicians actually respond to in real-time performance, particularly in free improvisation and much contemporary jazz practice, does not reside in symbolic notation. Instead, it emerges from the immediate sonic environment: timbre, density, articulation, gesture, and energetic change. This artistic report will demonstrate the online work of the Deep Improv project that explores these sonic dimensions as primary carriers of musical meaning through a machine-augmented improvisation system. Rather than analysing pitch or harmony directly, the system listens to the timbral behaviour of performers, including changes to sound parameters such as those produced through instrumental technique or live signal processing (for example, adjustments to effects pedals). These continuous timbral changes are analysed using machine learning models trained on data drawn from current and past performances. The system translates this information into audio- and MIDI-based cues that are reintroduced into the performance as prompts for further musical action. In addition to these timbre-driven cues, the system may introduce idiomatic references drawn from jazz practice, such as common harmonic progressions or short audio samples derived from well-known performances. These cues are not intended to prescribe musical outcomes, but to function as interpretive prompts within the improvisational flow. The work will be presented as a

10. Please insert here a **list of references.**

Berliner, P. F. (1994). Thinking in jazz: The infinite art of improvisation. University of Chicago Press.

Bown, O., Eldridge, A., & McCormack, J. (2015). Understanding interaction in contemporary digital music: From instruments to behavioural objects. Organised Sound, 20(2), 188–200. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1355771815000106

Cook, N. (2013). Beyond the score: Music as performance. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780199357406.001.0001

Godøy, R. I. (2010). Gestural affordances of musical sound. In R. I. Godøy & M. Leman (Eds.), Musical gestures: Sound, movement, and meaning (pp. 103–125). Routledge.

Grey, J. M. (1977). Multidimensional perceptual scaling of musical timbres. The Journal of the Acoustical Society of America, 61(5), 1270–1277. https://doi.org/10.1121/1.381428

Hatten, R. S. (2004). Interpreting musical gestures, topics, and tropes: Mozart, Beethoven, Schubert. Indiana University Press.

Ingarden, R. (1986). The work of music and the problem of its identity (A. Czerniawski, Trans.). University of California Press. (Original work published 1961)

Leman, M. (2007). Embodied music cognition and mediation technology. MIT Press.

Lewis, G. E. (2000). Too many notes: Computers, complexity and culture in Voyager. Leonardo Music Journal, 10, 33–39. https://doi.org/10.1162/096112100570585

Monson, I. (1996). Saying something: Jazz improvisation and interaction. University of Chicago Press.

Nattiez, J.-J. (1990). Music and discourse: Toward a semiology of music (C. Abbate, Trans.). Princeton University Press. (Original work published 1987)

Peeters, G. (2004). A large set of audio features for sound description (similarity and classification) in the CUIDADO project. IRCAM Technical Report.

Sawyer, R. K. (2006). Group creativity: Musical performance and collaboration. Psychology Press.

Smalley, D. (1997). Spectromorphology: Explaining sound-shapes. Organised Sound, 2(2), 107–126. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1355771897009059

Wishart, T. (1996). On sonic art. Routledge.

11. You may leave **comments** and **questions** in this space.

Apologies - uploading again, hope this is ok - there didn't seem to be any email notification of acceptance, so thought best to do again. Same as submission yesterday. Note also that we wrote a full paper for this one (hence the references), please let us know if this is also required at this time.